4-0

by Taylor Shann

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A bar, night. HELEN waits, checking her phone with a drink on the bar. Whatever is going on, she ain't happy. JACK walks by, in his softball shirt with a softball, cheering:

JACK:
FREE ENTERPRISE-ERS! FREE ENTERPRISE-ERS! FREE- (recognizes HELEN) Helen! Mr Boss man! Ms. Boss woman. Whatever!

HELEN:
I've been calling. Several times. Texted you, 911. No answer.

JACK:
No phones in the celebration zone!

HELEN:
So you won.

JACK:
WE won. Free Enterprise; best company softball team ever... (holds up ball) is 4-0. And we beat'em BAD. 10-2. Mark hit a homer, even the Intern scored a run. One more win, and our playoff slot is in the bag. I gotta send the results email-

HELEN:
Jack- did you, by chance, hit Bill Henderson with a pitch?

JACK:
I wasn't aiming for him, but dude should'a moved. It's softball, not baseball.

HELEN:
The 'dude' is Bill Henderson, and you hit him in the face. Bill's wife, Victoria Henderson, is the head of the Audubon society. Victoria called my boss, who called me, and now, I'm HERE. Talking to YOU.

JACK:
And we won! Up top! (beat) That means high five. Up top!

HELEN
Jack, I know the team is important to you, based on the emails you send out, to everyone, to people who work in the

Hong Kong office, I know, because they email me about it, and they say, what the hell is this, and why the hell is in my inbox, and how did he get all these different fonts into ONE email-

JACK:
I download them. I had to get past the work firewall, but, Rashmi helped with that.

HELEN:
…yeah. Here's the thing- the emails I can handle. But last month you threw beer cans at Doctors without Borders. Last week, you urinated in the ACLU's Water cooler; and it's on Youtube. Today, you gave a man a concussion. He may be bleeding internally. And do you know who you're playing next week?

JACK:
Uh... the... they help out retarded kids. (she stares at him) AF something. I dunno. Mark should know. (she stares at him) What?

HELEN:
The American Foundation for Disabled Children. Which is a charity that deals with DISABLED CHILDREN. I don't want to hear the R word again. Are we clear?

JACK:
Got it. No more reta- R words.

HELEN:
Good. You're playing them Wednesday. And Jack. You're going to lose.

JACK:
What?

HELEN:
You and Mark and Rashmi and Intern, the whole gang, are going to lose against the AFDC. You are going to not win. You will be good sports about not winning.

JACK:
(puts softball on the bar, leans back) Why would we do that?

HELEN:

We put the softball team together to make us- the company- look good. We are an energy company, but we play non profits for charity and social causes. For PR. For them to not sue us. For 8 years.

JACK:
8 years of losing, until I got voted captain. Now we're unbeatable.

HELEN
Yes! You have beat them! Badly! Free Enterprise is the undefeated giant dick all stars of the NYC Charity Softball League. And every time you pee in the proverbial cooler, they call me. EVERY. TIME.. I am literally, one crying down syndrome child away from getting fired. So next Wednesday night, your email will say, in 12 point Times New Roman only, "FREE ENTERPRISE. LOSES." Or I will make it my job to insure you no longer have one. Are we clear?

JACK laughs hysterically.

HELEN:
Excuse me?

JACK:
Every day I come in and I basically do the jobs of three people. Mark takes 2 hours to do what I do in 30 minutes. When I go on vacation, everything is on fire when I get back. So you're going to fire me? Over this?

HELEN:
I… spoke to HR. They say the decision is mine.

JACK:
And how are you going to meet your end of quarter deadline without me, exactly? Last I checked, you thought Excel was something that makes the internet work.

HELEN:
They SEE what you do all day. They track you on your computer, and what you do, after your work is done, is THIS. The team, the standings, the bar, the fonts.

JACK:
I just want to make sure I understand you. You want us to throw away a 4-0 record so, what exactly, non-profits will approve of what we do?

HELEN:
If them 'feeling better' means we don't show up on the blogs, and I still have my job, then… yes!

JACK:
Let me think about it. (picks up softball, tosses it in the air a few times) No. If you have to fire me, go ahead and fire me. Unemployment with Xbox sounds great. But no way is my team gonna throw a game against a bunch of retarded kids.

JACK goes to leave.

HELEN:
If you go 5-0, I'll disband the team.

JACK:
... You can't do that.

HELEN:
Take it up with HR. Lose, or lose your team and your record. No more equipment, entry fees, uniforms. No more bar tab. You're done.

JACK:
I'll quit.

HELEN:
Good luck collecting unemployment, then.

JACK:
You won't meet your end of quarter earnings.

HELEN:
I'll give Mark your job.

JACK:
Mark's an idiot!

HELEN:
Maybe, but Mark won't get me fired. (goes to leave)

JACK:
Damn it! (slams the softball on the bar). You took away espn.com. You took away Rum Fridays. You make me clock out when I go to the coffee cart. What did I ever do to you?

HELEN:
Do you think I care that you print out sports columns and read them in the bathroom? Do you think it matters to me that your trips to the 'coffee cart' involve posting on facebook about the fact that dr pepper is on sale at the CVS around the corner? Do I think alcohol is the devil? No! But when my boss finds those columns, on the floor of the bathroom and your NAME is on it; when you're not at your desk three times in a row on the same day in the same hour and my boss walks by, and when you walk through the front door with three twelve packs of soda you CLEARLY PURCHASED ON COMPANY TIME… they call me.

JACK:
So your solution is this?! Just tell me to stop!

HELEN:
I DID!

JACK:
WHEN?!

HELEN:
CHECK YOUR EMAIL!

JACK:
I WILL! (checks his email, it takes a good twenty seconds) WELL I DIDN'T READ THOSE, I'M SORRY.

HELEN:
FINE!

They both pause, still angry.

JACK:
I'm good at what I do.

HELEN:
I know, Jack. But you are such an ass.

JACK:
I've never lost on purpose. At anything. Ever. Not even when I played HALO with my little sister.

HELEN:
It's just one game.

JACK:

Yeah, for now. And what about the next charity? And the one after that? We got cancer, cars for kids, you name it.

HELEN:
Jack, this isn't about winning or losing. (picks up the ball) I'm just asking you play ball.

HELEN tosses the ball to him, he catches it.